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A WARM GESTURE PM Narendra Modi greets NDA's VP candidate C.P. Radhakrishnan in New Delhi, Aug. 19

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SAFFRON'S SOUTH BET

By elevating RSS veteran C.P. Radhakrishnan as VP nominee, BJP blends loyalty and identity in the party's bid to crack the Tamil Nadu fortress

By **ANILESH S. MAHAJAN**

AS THE BJP'S PARLIAMENTARY BOARD MET IN NEW DELHI ON August 16, nobody would have called the task at hand a routine one. The NDA's vice-presidential nominee was going to be named, after all. That too, to fill the space left by a contentious departure. But the final choice restored things to a comfortable groove for the BJP—a sense of desired order, going even beyond the routine.

The anointed one was C.P. Radhakrishnan, currently Maharashtra governor, a two-time Coimbatore MP before that and, more importantly, a former RSS state head in Tamil Nadu. It was straight out of the Narendra Modi playbook: ideological loyalty and identity fused in one figure, as the prime minister's strategic choices have preferred of late. As the chosen name passes through the filter